

right time. "How great that you hit Wall Street during the boom, the gala, the big chance," many said. That they kept asking when I was moving to Park Avenue only made reality more painful.

Several sought my investment advice. I know I've been giving you useful hints all along, but in the middle of my journey and with these results-to-date, to be regarded as a valuable source of investment counsel was frightening. I mention myself as an example of how little we know about the actual performance of the so-called experts we seek to emulate, from the neighborhood geniuses to the TV financial celebrities.

Since I didn't want to disappoint the believers, I often told them things I'd heard secondhand in my trips around Wall Street, such as: "Abbott Laboratories looks good, it's ready for a breakout," or "Gulf & Western Industries is undervalued at 48," or "Heinz is going straight to 50." This made them much happier than if I'd described my own firsthand experience in any detail.

I'd begun to understand why average investors sometimes lie to each other about money they haven't made. It's as hard to admit failure in a bull market as it is to say you've had a bad time in Venice. Admitting you had a bad time in Venice goes against 800 years of romantic expectations. Friends of the romantic Venice have too much riding on the idea of it to tolerate unhappy reports from people who've smelled the canals and fallen out of love. The actual condition of my portfolio to date made me think of this.

I kept up appearances as long as I could, retreating from "Angstrom's going great, I've doubled my money," to "I'm doing pretty well," to "Things are getting along OK." I hoped this "getting along OK" would discourage further inquiry, but it didn't. At several parties, I accepted the congratulations of admirers who announced: "He never made any money before, but now he's found his niche."

Back home, my wife and children remembered the exciting first weeks when I was proud to own Angstrom. They continued to think I'd prospered long after I'd hit the loss column, though I'd dropped several hints to prepare them for the truth. Fortunately, they never opened the Prudential-Bache monthly statements mailed to our home.

Once I'd told them the truth, I found myself casting about for